The Greydanus History

My father, Geert Greydanus, was born on Dec.1,1899 in Cubaaro, Friesland and died on Sept.14, 1965 in Clinton. He was the second child in a family of 9 children, 3 brothers and 6 sisters. His parents were Jacob Greydanus born on Jan.18, 1873 in Lollum, Friesland and he died on Sept.18, 1952 in Anjum, Friesland. His wife, Saakjie Hibma was born on Jan.2, 1877 in Dronryp, Friesland and died on August 5, 1962 in Anjum, Friesland. Both are buried in Friesland.

My mother Johanna (Jacobje) Pebesma was born on April 22, 1902 in Garyp, Friesland and died in Chatham on Feb.14, 1984. Both parents are buried in Clinton. Her parents were Jan Melles Pebesma, born on Dec.15, 1872 in Garyp, Friesland and died on August 10, 1942 in Brunssum, Limburg and Wytske Wybes Baron, born on October 10, 1872 in Garyp, Friesland and died on August 23, 1958 in Roermond, Limburg. They also had a family of 9 children, mother was no. 3. Times were very difficult, when there were 5 children, the family moved to Recklinghausen in the Ruhr area in Germany,(1907), where my Pake worked in the mines. Three more children were born in Germany. In 1916 during the first world war, the family moved back to Holland and lived in Treebeek, Limburg where the last child was born, Jitske (Joyce). She married an Englishman, John Patterson on Jan.10, 1948. She is the only survivor of the family and still lives in Coulsdon,(Surrey). My grandparents later moved from Treebeek to Brunssum.

Father and Mother married in Heerlen, Limburg on May 9, 1923. They moved to Rotterdam where father had been accepted into the police force. He was in uniform for a few years and then became a police detective, (rechercheur). He was twice promoted, first to brigadier and later to major. All the children were born in Rotterdam:Wietske, Mar. 14,1924, Jacob, January 16, 1927, Jan , June 4, 1928, Gerard Bouke, Feb.15, 1932, Corneilis Wiebe, November 6, 1936, Bernhard, October 6, 1944.

We moved several times in Rotterdam but the last 12 years in Holland we lived in a new block of apartments on the outskirts of the city,(south), at 359B West Varkenoordseweg. We lived on the first floor and had bedrooms on the third floor. Since there were no houses in front, we could see all the way to the village of Ysselmonde. On May 10, 1940, Germany invaded Holland. After they had bombed the centre of the city of Rotterdam, Holland surrendered on May 14, 1940 and the German occupation began. On April 9, 1943, a large percentage of the police force of Rotterdam was called in for extra duty to arrest and round up Jews. Father had forseen this possibility and knew that as a Christian he could not do that and he went into hiding that day. He was in hiding with the Satter family who lived on a farm near Varsseveld in the province of Gelderland. This family was very involved with the underground or resistance movement. Their farm was a centre for underground activities so naturally, father became involved in the underground work as well.

On Dec. 1, 1943, two plainsclothes police officers came to our home early in the morning and arrested us, mother, brothers and myself and took us by streetcar! to the police headquarters where we were put into prison. Next day we were taken by paddy wagon to the office of the S.S. for a hearing. We would be released they said if we told them where father was. Another night in prison and the next day some of father's own colleagues took us by train to the concentration camp in Vught. Jaap and Jan were put in the men's quarters and had their heads shaved! Gerard and Cor were with us in the women's camp. We soon heard that there

were several other families among the prisoners who were also there as hostages. Some had been there for 3 or 4 months already. In the week before Christmas, Herr S.S. Obergruppenfuhrer and General der Polizei, the very well known Rauter came to to our barrack and set all the hostages free on Dec.18, 1943! Great rejoicing!

In the meantime, father had had a very difficult time and had to be held back fom giving himself up. In the beginning of January, 1944, he travelled to our relatives in Friesland and we did as well for a family reunion. Since we were afraid that we could be arrested again, it was decided that the two youngest children, Gerard and Cor should stay with one of the families in Friesland. They stayed till after the liberation, with an uncle and aunt, Tjebbe and Klaske Tibma-Greydanus. They had a farm in Ezumazyl close to Anjum. They had one adopted daughter. Another sister of father's lived close by, Tante Siem Montsma, a widow with 4 sons. They also had a farm.

So only 4 of us went back to Rotterdam and father went back to the Satter family. In the first part of April 1944, father accepted the responsibility for the distribution of an illegal paper, "Trow". People needed to know the truth as the news that the Germans gave us was always in their favour and not true. Early on during the occupation, everyone had to turn in their radios as well as any copper objects that they owned. Father was already in Friesland for his new "job" but had to go back to Narsseveld once more to get his belongings. Soon after he arrived there was a S.S. Raid on the farm and he was caught on April 20, 1944. He was transported to the Vught concentration camp. There he underwent terrible hearings with torture. The Nazis wanted him to give the names of others involved in the liberation movement.

During the time that Father was in prison, the Allies liberated 90% of France, Belgium and also the southern part of Holland but they were unable to cross the very wide rivers - the Schelde. The Germans knew they were losing and committed a great many crimes. They dynamited the dykes and flooded the province of Zeeland. They destroyed the harbours along with the grain silos and warehouses in Rotterdam etc. They also executed many prisoners who were being held in the Vught prison. Father expected to be executed as well. Instead on August 9, 1944, he was transported by cattle - car train to Germany and ended up in Buchenwald Concentration Camp.

It is by God's grace that he survived. It is also true that he had a very strong will to survive, to not give up but rather to trust in the Lord to bring him through. Buchenwald was liberated on May 7, 1945, and father made his way back to Holland on his own, hitching rides with the canadian and american liberators.

In the meantime, we lived through the hunger winter. Food rations were very scarce and often not even available. We had no coal, no gas and no hydro. In the big cities, people died of hunger and malnutrition. All during the war, we received extra rations and food whenever possible from our relatives in Friesland. Ben was born in October. We took very good care of him and he ate everything we gave him. He survived wonderfully well! But the situation was getting worse all the time and so Jaap and Jan put two bikes together and took off for Friesland. The bikes did not hold up very well so they walked most of the distance and ended up exhausted at the home of Jan and Tante Jetske Greydanus - a great uncle and aunt -in Oudeschool. Later they went on to Genum and stayed with the Damsma and Buruma families till the war was over. Jan learned how to spin fleece of illegally slaughtered sheep and he became very good at it. Mother developed edema because of a lack of proper food so we decided that I should join three other girls who wanted to bike north in search of some extra food. That was a very wrong

decision! It took us 4 days with many scary experiences to reach Friesland. While we were there Holland was liberated except for the western provinces, so as a result we could not get home. We were separated and found places to stay here and there.

I was able to get a ride with two American soldiers, one of Friesian descent across the Afsluitdyk. That was strictly forbidden for citizens and they more than likely got into trouble over it. I made my way home from there myself, sick with jaundice., staying overnight twice with strangers. The people were very kind and one family had a paper with a list of Buchenwald survivors. What a joy to read Father's name on the list! I still have that paper.

I got home on May 22, 1945. Father had been home for more than a week already. Early in her pregnancy, mother had a dream which gave us hope throughout the remainder of the war. She dreamed that father had survived and had come home. The baby had been born and was 7 months old. And that is exactly what happened! It was an encouragement from the Lord in those very difficult times!

I cannot remember when all the boys came home. The trains had not been running since September 1944. Bridges were destroyed and the Germans had confiscated many trains, busses and streetcars. But eventually we were all back home together again. Father got his old job back again at the police headquarters.

After some time though, he was asked to sign a paper in which he admitted that he had refused to obey orders and in which he had to ask if he could please be re-instated! That was a hard blow and totally unexpected. Later Father was asked not to take it too seriously and that it was only a formality and they also offered him a promotion, more or less to smooth things over. But father refused and since he always had an adventurous desire to emigrate, he applied for emigration. That was not too easy either since at that time only farmers could emigrate and had to promise to work the first year in Canada for a farmer. It took some doing, but in the end we were accepted, the furniture was sold and we were to sail on the eighth of September 1947 on the Tabintha. It was a ship used to transport troops and was only the second ship to transport immigrants after the war. In 1946, our oldest brother , Jaap or Jacob was drafted into the army. At that time there was a conflict between the Netherlands and their colony, the Dutch East Indies, now Indonesia, who wanted their independence. So the Dutch soldiers had to go to Indonesia to prevent that from happening. Father did his utmost to get permission for Jaap to emigrate with the rest of us, but no permission was granted. Much later we were told that other soldiers were released from army service and allowed to emigrate, if they had a background in agriculture. So Jaap had to go to Indonesia and was killed when he had only been there for 10 days. It happened at night. There was a lot of confusion, wrong orders were given, two Dutch companies shot at each other and Jaap was shot through the knees. When he was found, he had already lost a lot of blood and he died a short time later. It happened at Passoeroean on the twenty-first of August, 1947. He was buried the next morning at the war cemetery near Soerbaja. That all happened a little more than 2 weeks before we boarded the ship to sail for Canada.

The first 10 years in Canada were difficult. We left Holland on Sept.8,1947 and arrived in Canada on the twenty-first. We had been assigned to work for Dalton Snyder , a farmer who lived in Baden and who also had a trucking business. He had asked for a family with older children. So besides Father, Gerard also worked for him and was very unhappy. He had just started at a vocational school in Rotterdam. Jan had to work for the farmer too but was soon dismissed. I had to work for Mrs. Snyder , working long days for $2. A day and I was also

unhappy. The work proved to be too much for Father, long days with never a day off. Mr. Snyder took advantage of us and did not treat us the way he should have. Father asked the immigration field man if he could find a different assignment and so we moved to Ridgetown to work for a chicken farmer, Mr. Berkenshaw.

The house that he had for us was small, shabby and neglected. We arrived there near the end of March. On May 9, 1948, on the eve of Father and Mother's 25th wedding anniversary, there was a violent storm with much rain. The roof of the house leaked and all the rain water ran to a low spot and in the middle of the night, the whole ceiling came down on a bed and a rack of clothes. The farmer was in a bad mood since lots of damage had been done to his chicken barn, so he refused to come and have a look at what had happened to our house. So then my parents took things in their own hands and with the help of some older immigrants, they found a farmer on the other side of Ridgetown who was looking for a family to pick 14 acres of tomatoes in shares. So we moved again to a brand new but very small house, but it had a large kitchen, livingroom combination and two small bedrooms. Much of the furniture had to be stored with other immigrants who had a very big house. After the tomato crop had been picked, we had to move again. We were able to rent a house 5 miles north of Dresden, the first house with running water and even a bathroom. We were married on Nov.27, 1948 and we lived upstairs so that we could share the rent of $ 35. The Lord provided work for all the men since all three were hired at the baseball factory of McVay in Dresden. The second spring that we lived there, was very wet and the ground water was very high. As a result we had no water and no plumbing. The landlord was not interested in helping us so we had to move again! We found a small house in Dresden with no running water or a bathroom and father and mother with the boys moved to an old house outside of town. This house also had no conveniences. That all happened in 1950. From there the family moved to a house outside of Chatham. Poor Cor had to move 6 times to a different school during those years. We moved in Sept.1951 to Wallaceburg as the house that we were living in was sold.

In 1955, father and mother bought a farm near Clinton for $3500. It had 90 acres of which 20 acres could be worked. It is now part of a conservation area. We bought a 50 acre farm near the village of Londesboro and moved there in the spring of 1954. We paid $5600. And all the land was workable and it had a large brick house. However, neither family did well on their farm. We lacked the know-how and money to succeed. Financially it was a very tough struggle, but also in many other ways.

Father forfeighted his police pension when he emigrated even though he had only 8 more years to go. In 1958, the decision was made in Holland that pensions should be paid to people who had emigrated. My parents received their pension retroactive to 1947. The first thing they did was take a three months vacation by boat to Holland. It has been reported that while they were in Holland, Father said that the emigration of our family was a mistake and should not have happened. Nevertheless, we are thankful and happy to live in Canada. Holland has become a totally different country and is in many ways not a good example anymore to the rest of the world.

Grandma met Pake on the boat. Pak left his whole family in Holland (Friesland) He wanted out, probably a new start after the war. His family was also very poor - didn't always have enough food for all the kids! (10 kids plus 1 adopted child)

CANADA

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CERTIFICATE OF CANADIAN CITIZENSHIP

DEPARTMENT OF CITIZENSHIP AND IMMIGRATION

CERTIFICAT DE CITOYENNETÉ CANADIENNE

MINISTÈRE DE LA CITOYENNETÉ ET DE L'IMMIGRATION

This is to certify that

Ce certificat atteste que

JACOBIE GREYDANUS

is a Canadian citizen under the provisions of the Canadian Citizenship Act and, as such, is entitled to all the rights and privileges and is subject to all the responsibilities, obligations and duties of a Canadian citizen.

est citoyen canadien aux termes de la Loi sur la citoyenneté canadienne et, à ce titre, jouit de tous les droits et privilèges et est assujetti(e) à tous les devoirs, obligations et responsabilités d'un citoyen canadien.

Laval Fortier

DEPUTY MINISTER
SOUS-MINISTRE

MINISTER
MINISTRE

PRINTED IN CANADA

DESCRIPTION — SIGNALEMENT

NAME *Nom* JACOBIE GREYDANUS

ADDRESS *Adresse* CLINTON, ONTARIO, CANADA

TRADE OR OCCUPATION *Profession* HOUSEWIFE

PLACE OF BIRTH *Lieu de naissance* THE NETHERLANDS

DATE OF BIRTH *Date de naissance* 22ND APRIL, 1902

MARITAL STATUS *Etat matrimonial* MARRIED

SEX *Sexe* F **HEIGHT** *Taille* 5' 6" **COMPLEXION** *Teint* MEDIUM

EYES *Yeux* BLUE **HAIR** *Cheveux* GREY

DISTINGUISHING MARKS *Marques particulières* NONE

This certificate granted pursuant to section 10 (1) shall be
Le présent certificat accordé en vertu de l'article *entrera*

effective on and from the 18th day of March 1955
en vigueur à compter du *jour de*

REGISTRAR OF CANADIAN CITIZENSHIP
Registraire de la Citoyenneté canadienne

CANADA

NUMBER
165116

SERIES A

CERTIFICATE OF CANADIAN CITIZENSHIP

ISSUED UNDER THE CANADIAN CITIZENSHIP ACT

I, the undersigned, Minister of Citizenship and Immigration, do hereby certify and declare that GEERT GREYDANUS whose particulars are endorsed hereon, is a Canadian citizen and that he/she is entitled to all rights, powers and privileges and subject to all obligations, duties and liabilities to which a natural-born Canadian citizen is entitled or subject.

In testimony whereof I have hereunto subscribed my name and affixed the Seal of the Department of Citizenship and Immigration, this TWENTY-EIGHTH day of MAY 1954

THIS CERTIFICATE SHALL BE EFFECTIVE ON AND FROM

Twenty-ninth DAY OF June, 1954

Laval Fortier

DEPUTY MINISTER OF CITIZENSHIP AND IMMIGRATION

N. E. Harris

MINISTER OF CITIZENSHIP AND IMMIGRATION

PRINTED IN CANADA

CERTIFICATE OF CANADIAN CITIZENSHIP

Particulars of Description

FULL NAME GEERT GREYDANUS

ADDRESS CLINTON, ONTARIO, CANADA

TRADE OR OCCUPATION FARMER

PLACE AND DATE OF BIRTH HENNAARDERADEEL, FRIESLAND, THE NETHERLANDS
1ST DECEMBER, 1899

SUBJECT OF CITIZEN OF THE NETHERLANDS

MARRIED OR SINGLE WIDOWER (WIDOW) MARRIED

NAME OF WIFE HUSBAND

PARENTS SUBJECTS CITIZENS OF THE NETHERLANDS

AGE 54 YEARS, HEIGHT 5 FEET 10 INCHES

COLOUR WHITE COMPLEXION MEDIUM

COLOUR OF EYES BLUE COLOUR OF HAIR BROWN, GRAYING

VISIBLE DISTINGUISHING MARKS NONE

(COUNTERSIGNED) [signature]
REGISTRAR OF CANADIAN CITIZENSHIP